

The Spare Room

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1. The Bag

RUTH sits at the table. HELEN stands behind her, holding RUTH's coat open. KIT has put a bag on the third chair.

RUTH: Is that for my things?

KIT: Yes.

RUTH: That's your swimming bag.

KIT: It's dry.

RUTH: I didn't ask whether it was wet.

HELEN: There's hardly anything to take.

RUTH: Good. It won't take long when I've decided.

HELEN: You have decided.

RUTH holds out a hand. HELEN moves the coat towards it.

RUTH: My glasses.

HELEN gives her the spectacles from the table.

KIT: I can get another bag.

HELEN: The bag is fine.

RUTH: I'm sure it is.

KIT: That sounded-

HELEN: It's fine.

KIT opens the bag.

KIT: What first?

HELEN: The blue mug.

RUTH: No.

HELEN: You said you wanted your own things around you.

RUTH: Some of them.

HELEN: You use it every day.

RUTH: It's the one that's here.

KIT picks up the mug.

RUTH: There's tea in that.

KIT puts it down.

KIT: Right.

HELEN: I'll drink it.

RUTH: It's cold.

HELEN: I don't mind.

HELEN has to put the coat down to pick up the mug. RUTH takes the coat and folds it across her knees.

KIT: I could start with clothes.

RUTH: You could sit down.

KIT: I've only got-

HELEN: We know.

RUTH: I don't.

KIT: I said I'd be back in an hour.

RUTH: Then you'd better not sit down.

HELEN drinks.

RUTH: I told you.

HELEN: It's all right.

RUTH: Your face says otherwise.

HELEN: Mum.

RUTH: What?

HELEN puts the mug down.

HELEN: We said we would do this today.

RUTH: You said today.

HELEN: And you said that would be-

RUTH: I said today was better than Thursday.

HELEN: Yes.

RUTH: I have something on Thursday.

HELEN: You could have told me that was what you meant.

RUTH: It was in the same sentence.

KIT: What's on Thursday?

HELEN: It doesn't matter what's on Thursday.

RUTH: It does to me.

A pause.

HELEN: Kit. You were here.

KIT: For which bit?

HELEN: When we discussed it.

KIT: I came in at the end.

HELEN: You heard her say today would be better.

KIT: I heard Thursday.

HELEN: You must have heard more than the word Thursday.

KIT: I was looking for my bag.

They all look at the bag.

RUTH: There it is.

KIT almost laughs. HELEN sees.

KIT: Sorry.

HELEN: I asked you to come and help.

KIT: I am trying to help. What goes in the bag?

RUTH starts unfolding the coat.

HELEN moves to assist her. RUTH folds it again, more neatly.

RUTH: Don't put clothes in with the mug.

KIT: I haven't put anything in.

RUTH: I can see that.

KIT lifts the bag off the chair and puts it on the floor. To sit down, they move the chair away from the table.

HELEN: Leave that where it was.

RUTH: It's in the way there.

HELEN: It's always been there.

RUTH: Yes.

KIT remains standing, holding the chair.

KIT: Here?

RUTH: That's fine.

HELEN: There isn't room.

KIT sits.

KIT: There is.

HELEN looks at the empty bag. She picks it up and holds it open herself.

HELEN: Your scarf, then. Can we put your scarf in?

RUTH considers this.

RUTH: The light one.

HELEN finds it beneath the coat. She places it in the bag.

RUTH: If we go.

HELEN: You asked me to find somewhere.

RUTH: I asked you to show me what there was.

HELEN: I showed you three places.

RUTH: You sent me six.

HELEN: You only looked at three.

RUTH: I only liked one.

KIT: Which one?

RUTH looks at them.

RUTH: I didn't say I liked it.

KIT: No.

RUTH: You have to be careful with her.

HELEN: Apparently.

KIT: Was it Sal's?

RUTH: Sal doesn't own it.

HELEN: She lives there.

RUTH: So do eight other people. That doesn't make it Sal's.

KIT: Nine?

RUTH: Sometimes.

HELEN: You said the tour was impossible.

RUTH: The tour was impossible. Sal kept saying, 'This is where we sit,' when only two of them were sitting and neither of them stayed the same person long enough to finish the tea.

KIT: Did you finish yours?

RUTH: There weren't any cups.

HELEN: There were cups.

RUTH: There were things you could drink from. That's not the same as having cups.

KIT: I like her.

RUTH: You haven't met her.

KIT: I like her cups.

RUTH: There weren't any.

KIT holds up both hands. RUTH conceals a smile by inspecting the coat.

HELEN: You went back.

RUTH: Once.

HELEN: Twice.

RUTH: The second time I was already nearby.

HELEN: Nearby where?

RUTH: Nearby them.

HELEN: You didn't tell me.

RUTH: I didn't know visits needed reporting before I'd agreed to be moved there.

HELEN: They don't.

RUTH: Good. I brought up looking.

HELEN: Looking isn't moving.

RUTH: No. That's why they're different words.

HELEN: Then what did you think today was?

RUTH: Better than Thursday.

HELEN: Kit said you were ready.

KIT becomes very interested in the zip of the bag.

RUTH: Did they?

HELEN: Yes.

KIT: I said it sounded as though you were.

HELEN: You said, 'She's ready.'

KIT: It did sound like that.

RUTH: Not when I said it.

KIT: I had to give Mum something definite.

RUTH: Why?

KIT: Because she kept asking.

HELEN: I asked once.

KIT: You asked once in several places.

RUTH: I didn't hear any of them.

HELEN: You wouldn't.

A fraction of a pause. RUTH looks at HELEN, but HELEN has already turned on KIT.

HELEN: You made me think she'd agreed.

KIT: You wanted me to come.

HELEN: That isn't an answer.

KIT: It's why I said yes before I knew what yes meant.

RUTH: Whose yes?

KIT: Hers. Yours. Mine. At the time they seemed to be travelling together.

RUTH: They weren't.

KIT: I can see that now.

RUTH: You can see three people in a room. It's not advanced work.

KIT: No.

HELEN: Mum, I am asking you now.

RUTH: No, you're not. You're asking again and pretending the first answer was mine.

HELEN puts the bag on the table.

HELEN: Fine. Will you move today?

RUTH looks at the bag. Then at her daughter.

RUTH: Stop packing.

HELEN: There is one scarf in it.

RUTH: Take it out.

HELEN: You said the light one.

RUTH: I am saying take it out.

HELEN takes out the scarf. She lays it on the table.

RUTH: Thank you.

KIT closes the empty bag.

RUTH: And don't do that.

KIT opens it again.

The three of them regard the open, empty bag.

2. The Other Promise

The bag remains open on the table. No one has found a graceful way to begin again.

KIT: I need to check something.

HELEN: Now?

KIT: It won't take long.

RUTH: Your hour will still be there when you get back.

KIT: That's what I'm checking.

KIT goes through the entrance.

RUTH: Take your bag.

KIT does not answer.

RUTH: Kit?

Nothing.

RUTH: Well, that's rude.

HELEN: They can't hear you from there.

RUTH: It isn't far.

HELEN: It isn't here.

RUTH: They managed to hear you asking about Thursday from somewhere I couldn't.

HELEN: That was different.

RUTH: Things often are by the time you explain them.

HELEN takes the bag from the table and puts it on the floor.

RUTH: That's still packing.

HELEN: It's making room.

RUTH: For what?

HELEN: My arms.

RUTH: Put them down.

HELEN does. RUTH waits for her to sit. HELEN does not.

RUTH: Have you got somewhere else to be?

HELEN: Yes.

RUTH: I meant now.

HELEN: So did I.

RUTH: Then go.

HELEN: I can't leave this half done.

RUTH: It hasn't begun.

HELEN: Exactly.

RUTH: That's not the same half.

HELEN takes a breath, then goes through the entrance.

RUTH waits.

RUTH: I told Sal you were very thorough.

No answer.

RUTH: She thought I meant kind.

No answer.

RUTH: Helen.

HELEN (*from beyond the entrance*): What?

RUTH: Nothing.

HELEN: You called me.

RUTH: You'd gone.

HELEN: For one minute.

RUTH: You didn't say.

HELEN: I am saying now.

RUTH: All right.

A pause.

RUTH: Were you doing something?

HELEN: Yes.

RUTH: Important?

HELEN: It was private.

RUTH: I didn't ask what it was.

HELEN: You asked if it was important.

RUTH: You could have said no.

HELEN returns.

HELEN: This. This is why.

RUTH: Why what?

HELEN: Kit goes out and you can't reach them. I go out and you follow me.

RUTH: I didn't move.

HELEN: You know what I mean.

RUTH: You answered.

HELEN: Because if I don't, you keep calling.

RUTH: I called once.

HELEN: Today.

RUTH: Once today.

HELEN: We have been here six minutes.

RUTH: Seven, if Kit's hour is reliable.

HELEN: It isn't the amount of room. It isn't the work. It is that there is nowhere I can go where you cannot ask me back.

RUTH looks around.

RUTH: You can go anywhere.

HELEN: So long as I can be interrupted here.

RUTH: I don't interrupt you when you're busy.

HELEN: You don't always know.

RUTH: You can tell me.

HELEN: Then I have to come here to tell you.

RUTH: You just told me from outside.

HELEN: That is not better.

RUTH: It was quite efficient.

HELEN: Mum.

RUTH: Helen.

They look at one another. For a moment the old form of the quarrel is almost comforting.

RUTH: I didn't know you were talking privately.

HELEN: I know.

RUTH: You make me sound as though I was listening at a door.

HELEN: There isn't a door you can stay behind.

RUTH: There's that one.

HELEN: It doesn't do that for us.

RUTH: It did for Kit.

HELEN: Kit doesn't live here.

The sentence is plain. Its meaning is not yet fully plain to the audience. RUTH looks at the empty bag.

RUTH: Neither do you, most of the time.

HELEN: I am always here.

RUTH: That's not what you say when I ask.

HELEN: Because you mean this.

RUTH: What else would I mean?

HELEN: Everything else.

RUTH: You can't call everything else a place and expect me to visit it.

HELEN: I haven't asked you to visit.

RUTH: No.

HELEN hears that.

HELEN: Sal has asked you.

RUTH: Sal asks everybody. That's why there are nine of them.

HELEN: You said eight.

RUTH: Sal makes nine.

HELEN: You said eight other people.

RUTH: Did I?

HELEN: Yes.

RUTH: Then there are ten.

HELEN: You don't know how many people live in the place you're considering moving to.

RUTH: They don't always count in the same direction.

HELEN: That doesn't worry you?

RUTH: Of course it worries me. One of them tried to show me a dance and I couldn't tell whose turn it was.

HELEN: You said you liked it.

RUTH: I said Sal was better when she wasn't showing me round.

HELEN: You went back.

RUTH: I was invited.

HELEN: You're invited here.

RUTH: I was.

HELEN is stopped by the tense.

RUTH: I could keep out of your way.

HELEN: You shouldn't have to keep out of anybody's way.

RUTH: That's a very nice reason for making me leave.

HELEN: I want you to have somewhere that isn't mine.

RUTH: And if I like it?

HELEN: Good.

RUTH: You don't sound sure.

HELEN: I am trying not to sound pleased.

RUTH: That wasn't the danger.

KIT returns. Their composure arrives a fraction before they do.

KIT: Fine.

HELEN: What is?

KIT: Everything.

RUTH: How many people?

KIT: What?

RUTH: Never mind. Did your hour survive?

KIT: More or less.

HELEN: Who were you checking with?

KIT: Neri.

HELEN: About what?

KIT: Tonight.

RUTH: There. You could have said it was private.

KIT: It wasn't.

HELEN: What's tonight?

KIT: The meal.

HELEN: Which meal?

KIT: The first one.

HELEN: Kit.

KIT: You said you'd try.

HELEN: You said you would tell me when it was settled.

KIT: It is settled. That's why I'm telling you.

HELEN: Now.

KIT: I tried before.

RUTH: Was that when I called?

KIT looks at HELEN. HELEN does not answer for them.

KIT: Yes.

RUTH: I didn't know.

KIT: I know.

RUTH: I wouldn't have-

KIT: It's fine.

RUTH: Stop saying that.

KIT: All right.

HELEN: What did Neri say?

KIT: They said they're beginning whether we're there or not.

RUTH: Sensible.

KIT: It isn't meant as a punishment.

RUTH: I didn't say it was.

KIT: It sounded-

HELEN: Kit.

KIT: Sorry.

HELEN: I said I'd try to come.

KIT: Yes.

HELEN: I did not say today depended on Mum moving.

KIT: No.

RUTH: It seems to.

KIT: Only because we're all here.

RUTH: You arranged that.

KIT: I helped.

HELEN: You told me she was ready.

KIT: We have done this part.

HELEN: We have not finished it.

KIT: Then can we finish something else?

RUTH: Such as me?

KIT: I didn't mean-

RUTH: I know. But you should listen to yourself occasionally. It's cheaper than having a family.

KIT laughs despite herself. RUTH does too. HELEN tries not to and fails.

KIT: Neri and I are going to live with them. Properly. From tonight.

RUTH: All ten?

KIT: Nine.

RUTH: That's what Sal claims.

HELEN: This is a different house.

RUTH: I know that. I am comparing arithmetic.

KIT: They can begin without us. They will. I just wanted Mum there when we arrived.

HELEN: You said you wanted me to meet them.

KIT: I do.

HELEN: That isn't the same thing.

KIT: No.

RUTH: You can go.

HELEN: We haven't settled this.

RUTH: You can come back.

HELEN: And you can call me before I do.

RUTH: I won't.

HELEN: You don't always know when you're calling me away.

RUTH: Then don't go. Stay here and do it.

KIT: Could we try it without anyone leaving?

They turn to KIT.

KIT: Mum stays here and does whatever she would do elsewhere. Ruth doesn't call her back. If that works, nobody has to make today mean more than it does.

HELEN: I would still be here.

KIT: Differently.

RUTH: How differently?

HELEN: You know.

RUTH: I know what you look like when you stop listening.

HELEN: That isn't what happens.

RUTH: Then show me.

HELEN: This is not a trick.

RUTH: I didn't say it was.

KIT: If it works, we can go tonight and talk about the rest when we aren't trying to beat two doors.

RUTH: There is one door.

KIT: It is doing a lot.

HELEN: And if it doesn't work?

RUTH: You can have your argument back.

HELEN: It isn't mine.

RUTH: You brought a bag.

HELEN considers RUTH. Then KIT. Then the room she has been trying not to name.

HELEN: You have to let me finish.

RUTH: Finish what?

HELEN: Whatever I begin.

RUTH: How long?

HELEN: I don't know yet.

RUTH: That's convenient.

HELEN: Mum.

RUTH: I will keep quiet.

KIT: Properly?

RUTH: I am capable of it.

HELEN: No calling me back.

RUTH: I said I will keep quiet.

HELEN: That isn't the same promise.

RUTH: It's the one you're getting.

KIT starts to close the open bag, thinks better of it, and leaves it where it is.

HELEN sits.

RUTH folds her hands.

KIT stops looking towards the entrance.

3. Being Here Differently

HELEN waits.

RUTH: Go on.

HELEN: I am.

RUTH: All right.

A little time.

KIT: You don't have to watch her.

RUTH: Where would you like me to look?

KIT: Anywhere.

RUTH: That's where I'm looking.

HELEN laughs once, unwillingly. She settles further into the chair, turned a little towards KIT. Her feet and hands cease their small readiness to attend to RUTH. Nothing makes her vacant or solemn. She is interested in something.

RUTH: Is that it?

HELEN: Nearly.

RUTH: Tell me when.

HELEN: Mum.

RUTH: Then I can start being quiet.

KIT turns towards HELEN.

KIT: Is it the harbour?

HELEN nods.

KIT: Can I?

HELEN: Yes. Wait. Let it come to you.

KIT sits. Their shoulders rise. They laugh, surprised.

KIT: Oh, that's cold.

HELEN: You asked.

KIT: Where am I standing?

HELEN: Don't stand anywhere.

KIT: I have to stand somewhere.

HELEN: That's why you keep falling in.

KIT adjusts, concentrating.

RUTH: Are your feet wet?

KIT: No.

RUTH: Well.

HELEN: You can have a look.

RUTH: I'm quite comfortable.

HELEN: You don't have to get up.

RUTH: I know that, Helen.

HELEN lets the offer go.

KIT: Someone's left a-

HELEN: I know.

KIT: They'll lose it.

HELEN: It's tied on.

RUTH: What is?

HELEN: A small boat.

RUTH: What kind?

HELEN: Red.

RUTH: That's not a kind of boat.

KIT: Very small. With something in it.

HELEN almost speaks.

KIT: A shoe.

HELEN looks at KIT.

KIT: Sorry. You were just looking at it.

HELEN: You can look. You don't have to say everything.

KIT: It was a very sudden shoe.

RUTH: Shoes do turn up in boats.

HELEN: Do they?

RUTH: If someone goes out wearing two and comes back wearing one, that's where I'd look.

KIT bends with laughter. HELEN joins them.

RUTH: What?

KIT: Nothing.

RUTH: I haven't said anything funny.

HELEN: You sounded so pleased with yourself.

RUTH: Well, I've solved it.

They are still amused. RUTH allows herself to be too.

KIT: Did you put the shoe there?

HELEN: No. I don't do the shoes.

RUTH: What do you do?

HELEN: The water.

RUTH: All of it?

HELEN: Enough of it.

KIT: She did the steps.

HELEN: I didn't do the steps. I made the water reach them together.

RUTH: Is that difficult?

HELEN: Yes.

RUTH: I only asked.

HELEN: No, I'm telling you. It's very difficult. The harbour narrows here, and then there's a bit nobody admits is a harbour because the houses are horrible. It is still a harbour. Water doesn't look at the houses and make a decision. So if you want the same wave to reach both sets of steps, you have to let it come round the long way without making the people in the middle think you've forgotten them. I had it once. Yesterday. They were all standing there with their feet just above it, waiting. And then a child jumped in early. Which was fair enough. It was water.

KIT: I would have.

HELEN: You'd have complained about the temperature first.

RUTH: Were the parents there?

HELEN: Probably. Mum, that's not- I liked it. They'd all been waiting for something very beautiful and this child made a horrible noise and everyone got splashed. I liked that better. I tried to tell the others and they thought I meant we should arrange it that way. Put the child in. Put the noise in. Which is completely-

She cannot find the word. She makes a frustrated gesture. KIT has received something of it and begins to laugh.

HELEN: No. Don't say it.

KIT: I wasn't going to.

HELEN: You were.

KIT: You're still showing me.

HELEN: Then stop enjoying it so much.

She looks towards RUTH, still smiling.

HELEN: You'd have liked it.

RUTH: It sounds messy.

HELEN: It was.

RUTH: Were you in it?

HELEN: Yes.

RUTH: On the steps?

HELEN: There as well.

RUTH: Well, I wouldn't have known where to wave.

HELEN: You could have waved anywhere.

RUTH: I don't wave at water. People take you home.

HELEN laughs. KIT does too, then stops as a second thought comes.

KIT: Did they say it was yours?

HELEN: What?

KIT: The tide.

HELEN: It doesn't matter.

KIT: Did they?

HELEN: They said we'd done a good job.

KIT: Ah.

RUTH: You always did want your name on things.

HELEN: It's nice when you've made them.

RUTH: You wrote it on the sofa.

HELEN: I didn't make the sofa.

RUTH: No. That was my point.

HELEN turns partly towards KIT again, her attention easy between them and the water. RUTH watches her.

RUTH: Will you be back for tea?

HELEN: I'm here.

RUTH: Later.

HELEN: I don't know what you mean.

RUTH: Neither do I, apparently.

A pause.

KIT: Neri said you could do something like that tonight.

HELEN: I said I'd try to come.

KIT: I know.

HELEN: You haven't asked me to do a tide.

KIT: No. Something little.

HELEN: I said I'd try to come.

KIT: It doesn't have to be anything.

RUTH: She has work to do.

KIT: She was just saying she likes it.

RUTH: I like dancing. I don't dance every time someone opens a door.

HELEN: You used to.

RUTH: That was my job.

KIT: Didn't you once-

RUTH: No, because everyone tells that wrong.

KIT: I haven't told it yet.

RUTH: Your mother will. It was a Friday. I know it was Friday because we couldn't have the hall on Saturdays. The man with the pigeons had it.

HELEN: He raced them.

RUTH: Not in the hall.

KIT: That would be a very short race.

RUTH: They had meetings. Anyway. I called left when I should have called right. In the first dance. Everyone went left. Perfectly reasonable. But I went on calling the next bit as though they'd gone right, and by then they were all halfway across the hall and the pianist couldn't see me.

HELEN: There wasn't a pianist.

RUTH: There was somebody making a noise.

KIT: The pigeons.

RUTH laughs before she can stop herself.

RUTH: Will you let me finish?

HELEN: Go on.

RUTH: Now I don't know where I was.

KIT: Nobody does. They're all going left.

They laugh. RUTH shakes her head at KIT, then begins laughing again.

RUTH: It was quite a good dance, as it turned out. A woman came up afterwards. 'So refreshing.' She had a hat on. I remember thinking she'd kept that on all evening and nobody had knocked it off. We must have done something right.

HELEN: Did you tell her?

RUTH: I said thank you.

The laughter subsides without turning against anyone.

RUTH: Go on. Finish it.

HELEN: I can stop.

RUTH: I said I'd wait.

HELEN turns towards KIT. Their attention follows something together. KIT nearly speaks; HELEN's smile stops them. They watch it finish.

RUTH waits. She does not call, prompt or ask them to return. Leave enough time for the shared pleasure to continue without her.

HELEN: There. That worked.

HELEN looks towards RUTH. Her feet stay where they are; her attention does not gather into its earlier pattern.

RUTH: I didn't call you.

HELEN: I know.

RUTH: Are you coming back now?

HELEN: I'm here.

RUTH: Properly.

RUTH cannot complete what she was going to say.

KIT: She doesn't have to stop everything.

RUTH: I didn't ask her to.

KIT: You did just-

HELEN: Kit.

HELEN gives RUTH her hand, palm upwards. RUTH begins to take it in an ordinary clasp.

HELEN: You can come and look. You don't have to stay.

RUTH lets go before taking her hand fully.

RUTH: I said I'd keep quiet.

HELEN: You don't have to keep quiet.

RUTH: Then why are we doing this?

HELEN: Because you live in me, Mum. When I go somewhere, you can still call me. If you're staying, I need to be able to be like this here sometimes.

RUTH: You can.

HELEN: All right.

A pause.

RUTH: Could you come back for a minute first?

HELEN looks at her. Then she turns her chair square to RUTH, sets both feet down, and waits. The familiar readiness returns. No lighting change.

HELEN: What is it?

RUTH: Nothing. I was-

Silence.

RUTH: Sal said she'd show me before the others arrived.

HELEN: The dance?

RUTH: I've kept saying Thursday.

RUTH takes the scarf from the table.

RUTH: I'll go now.

HELEN: You don't have to say that now.

RUTH: If I arrive after they've started, I'll just stand there nodding as though I know it.

KIT: The bag's here.

KIT rises immediately.

RUTH: I can see the bag.

KIT: Sorry.

RUTH opens it.

4. The Chair Stops the Move

RUTH folds the scarf once and puts it in the bag. She is much quicker at this than either visitor. She retrieves her spectacles.

HELEN: Put those somewhere you can find them.

RUTH: I have a place.

She puts them in her coat pocket.

HELEN: You'll forget they're there.

RUTH: You can tell me I told you so on Thursday.

KIT: So Thursday is Sal's?

RUTH: Thursday has been Sal's for a while.

HELEN: You didn't like it.

RUTH: I didn't like the person who showed us round.

HELEN: That was Sal.

RUTH: She's better when she isn't showing you round.

HELEN: I sent you two other places.

RUTH: I know.

HELEN: You could have told me.

RUTH: You'd already sent them.

HELEN picks up the mug.

HELEN: This?

RUTH: No. Sal's got cups.

KIT: You said she didn't.

RUTH: She's bought some.

KIT: For you?

RUTH: Not everything's for me.

RUTH takes the mug from HELEN, wipes its base with her thumb, and puts it on the table.

HELEN: They drink tea now?

RUTH: Some of them. They made quite a fuss about the cake.

KIT: Did they eat it?

RUTH: They admired it.

HELEN: You brought a whole cake?

RUTH: Well, I wasn't taking them one with a bit out.

KIT shoulders the bag. HELEN notices KIT turn, briefly, towards something neither woman has addressed.

HELEN: Still got the water?

KIT: Just a bit.

HELEN: Leave that bit alone.

KIT: I'm not doing anything to it.

HELEN: You were about to.

KIT grins. HELEN nearly does.

KIT: Are you going to teach them?

RUTH: Sal asked if I'd call.

HELEN: You said you couldn't follow it.

RUTH: They're showing me.

HELEN: You said you couldn't tell whose feet were whose.

RUTH: I couldn't.

HELEN: That doesn't sound-

RUTH: You didn't mind being all that water.

HELEN puts the coat over her arm.

HELEN: You can come back here afterwards. Tell me how it went.

RUTH: Not tonight.

HELEN: Tomorrow, then.

RUTH: I don't know.

HELEN: I'm trying to arrange a visit.

RUTH: We've barely managed to arrange leaving.

KIT: We could have done both by now.

HELEN: Kit, please.

HELEN puts the coat on the chair RUTH habitually uses.

HELEN: It'll all be here. You won't have to worry about that. You can come and sit-

RUTH lifts the coat and moves the chair away from its place.

HELEN: What are you doing?

RUTH: Getting my coat.

HELEN: You don't need to move that.

RUTH: It's in the way.

HELEN: It was fine.

RUTH: Put it wherever you like when I've gone.

HELEN puts it back.

KIT: Mum.

HELEN: What?

KIT: Nothing.

RUTH: That's not where it was.

HELEN: That's exactly where it was.

RUTH: Not at home. I got rid of that chair.

HELEN: No, you didn't.

RUTH: I think I'd remember.

HELEN: You sat in it every evening.

RUTH: For a while. It hurt the back of my leg. I gave it to the woman downstairs.

HELEN: You told me she borrowed it.

RUTH: She was borrowing everything. I wanted her to keep something.

RUTH moves the chair again, further from the table.

HELEN: I remember you in it.

RUTH: Well, here I am.

HELEN: I wasn't-

RUTH: Put it back yourself if you want it there.

HELEN does not move it.

KIT: I've got everything. Shall we?

HELEN: Wait.

KIT: What?

HELEN: Just wait.

HELEN takes the bag from KIT.

KIT: I'll carry it.

HELEN: We haven't-

She sets it behind her chair.

RUTH: Give that back.

HELEN: I'm trying to understand what you've agreed to.

RUTH: I'm going to Sal's.

HELEN: And after that?

RUTH: I'll take my coat off.

HELEN: You know what I mean.

RUTH: Actually I don't.

HELEN: You said they don't always have-

She gestures at RUTH.

RUTH: These? No. Not always.

HELEN: And you won't?

RUTH: I might like it.

HELEN: But when you come here.

RUTH: When I come here what?

HELEN: Here. Like this. We can agree that much.

RUTH: We haven't.

RUTH: You held your hand out to me just now.

HELEN: Yes.

RUTH: I saw it. I couldn't do it. That doesn't mean I won't ever do anything.

HELEN: I didn't say that.

RUTH: Then give me my bag.

HELEN: I don't want the next time I see you to be something you haven't told me about.

RUTH: I don't know what to tell you about yet.

HELEN: You could wait until you do.

RUTH: And if I walk out now, you'll tell Kit we arranged Thursday here.

HELEN: We could.

RUTH: I'm waiting for you to say we haven't.

KIT looks from the bag to HELEN.

KIT: We came to take her.

HELEN: I know why we came.

KIT: She's ready.

HELEN: She's upset.

RUTH: Then don't upset me any more. Give me the bag.

RUTH reaches for the bag. HELEN holds it.

RUTH: Helen.

HELEN lets RUTH take one handle. She keeps the other. Neither pulls.

5. An Invitation Misused

KIT: Are you going to expect me to do this for you?

HELEN: Of course not.

RUTH: I didn't expect it either.

RUTH releases her handle. She stays facing HELEN. HELEN puts the bag under her own chair.

KIT: Then why is she still here?

RUTH: Ask her.

HELEN: I asked you to stay.

RUTH: Yes.

HELEN: I've never said I didn't.

RUTH: You say it as though I came to dinner and wouldn't put my coat on.

HELEN: Mum.

RUTH: I had a coat on. I was going somewhere.

HELEN: I know.

RUTH: The others waited for me.

HELEN: I know that too.

KIT: What others?

RUTH: We were going round together. Calling dances. A different place every-

HELEN: You hadn't said yes to them either.

RUTH: I had my coat on.

HELEN: You were standing in the passage.

RUTH: And you asked me to sit down.

A pause.

HELEN: Yes.

RUTH: I wasn't the one who wanted all this.

RUTH looks around the room. HELEN follows her look as far as the chair.

KIT: You don't have to keep it because you wanted it once.

RUTH: Who's talking to you?

KIT: Everyone. When they want me to carry something.

RUTH: You keep picking things up.

HELEN: Can you both stop?

They stop. HELEN sits. She looks towards the chair again.

RUTH: You wanted me to talk.

HELEN: I remember.

RUTH: I'd done the shopping.

HELEN: I remember that as well.

RUTH: Two kinds of potatoes. You wanted to know why.

HELEN: I was trying to keep you talking.

RUTH: I know that now. I gave you quite a long answer.

HELEN laughs very slightly. It does not quite become a laugh.

KIT: How long was she meant to stay?

HELEN: There wasn't a-

RUTH: As long as I liked.

HELEN is still looking at the chair.

RUTH: That was what you said. Not until Thursday. Not until you'd found something else to do. As long as I liked.

HELEN's attention slips from RUTH to the chair. KIT follows the shift, as they followed her attention to the shoe. They receive something silently: a moment as HELEN remembers it, not an account of the whole night. KIT looks at HELEN, then at the bag and the entrance. They choose to speak.

KIT: She was on the floor.

HELEN looks at KIT.

RUTH: What?

KIT: When she said it. She was on the floor. She asked you to breathe louder.

A silence.

RUTH: Who told you that?

KIT: Mum just-

HELEN: I didn't.

KIT: You were-

HELEN: I didn't say it.

KIT: No. But you were there again. Just then.

RUTH looks at HELEN. HELEN does not look back.

KIT: You were frightened then. You aren't now. Give her the bag.

HELEN: You don't know what I asked her after that.

KIT: You can't keep making her be frightened so that you-

HELEN: Stop.

HELEN turns to KIT. She holds out her palm. KIT starts to take it. HELEN closes her hand and places it on the table.

KIT draws back, abruptly alone in their own posture.

KIT: Oh.

HELEN waits.

KIT: The water's gone.

KIT: I wasn't trying to look at that.

HELEN: But you said it.

KIT: It was there. With the water.

HELEN: I know where it was.

KIT: You let me-

HELEN: To see something I'd made. I wanted to show you.

KIT looks at her, tries to begin again.

KIT: Mum.

HELEN waits. KIT has to make the request aloud.

KIT: Can I come back?

HELEN: No.

HELEN gets up and goes through the entrance. KIT stays where they are.

KIT: Mum?

No answer.

RUTH: Helen.

HELEN *(from beyond the entrance):* What?

RUTH: I didn't mean to-

HELEN *(from beyond the entrance):* I'm coming.

HELEN returns. KIT has no shared view of her experience. RUTH has reached her in the same way she did before the trial.

Silence. No one finds a job.

RUTH: I thought you'd gone to sleep.

HELEN: Not then.

RUTH: No. I know. You kept waking-

She stops.

A little time.

KIT: We're late.

HELEN: Go, then.

KIT: Neri's expecting you.

HELEN: I said I'd try.

KIT: I know.

HELEN: What did you tell them?

KIT: I thought we'd be finished.

HELEN: What did you tell them?

KIT: Yes.

HELEN nods once.

KIT: You said you'd try. You always say that. I thought if I said you were coming, you'd-

HELEN: I'd what?

KIT: Come.

RUTH sits down. The displaced chair is awkwardly far from the table. She stays where it is.

KIT: I wanted you there.

HELEN: You could have asked me.

KIT: I did ask you. You said you were listening and then she called and you said one minute. So I waited. I was still there when you came back. You didn't remember I was still there.

HELEN cannot immediately answer.

KIT: I know I shouldn't have said it. The thing just now. I know. But I'm not making that bit up.

HELEN: No.

KIT: Will you come?

HELEN: I can't promise you that now.

KIT: They're waiting for us.

HELEN: They don't know they're waiting for us.

KIT: They know I'm here.

HELEN: You have to tell Neri what you said.

KIT: I could tell them we're nearly-

HELEN looks at KIT.

KIT: All right.

KIT goes to the entrance. They look back at HELEN, then at the bag.

KIT: I'll come back.

RUTH: We heard you.

KIT leaves.

HELEN and RUTH sit apart. The bag is under HELEN's chair.

Neither speaks.

6. Without the Witness

The silence continues after KIT has gone.

RUTH looks at the entrance. HELEN looks at the bag beneath her chair.

RUTH: You taught them that.

HELEN: What?

RUTH: Saying they will come back when they mean they would like to be forgiven later.

HELEN: I didn't teach them to repeat something they had no right to know.

RUTH: No.

HELEN: You don't have to make it smaller.

RUTH: I'm not.

HELEN: You are already trying to make me feel sorry for them.

RUTH: You do feel sorry for them.

HELEN: That doesn't make it yours to arrange.

RUTH: I haven't arranged anything all day.

HELEN: You arranged Thursday.

RUTH: Thursday is not today.

HELEN: Apparently.

Another silence.

RUTH: I didn't know you were frightened like that.

HELEN: You were there.

RUTH: I knew you were upset.

HELEN: I was on the floor.

RUTH: You wouldn't sit in the chair.

HELEN: I couldn't feel where it ended.

RUTH: You didn't say that.

HELEN: There were several things I didn't say.

RUTH: You said breathe.

HELEN: Louder.

RUTH: So I did.

HELEN: I know.

RUTH: I thought you were listening for the time between breaths.

HELEN: I was.

RUTH: You never told me.

HELEN: It wasn't a story then.

RUTH takes that. She looks at the bag again.

RUTH: The group were waiting.

HELEN: They were waiting for your answer.

RUTH: They had a room booked.

HELEN: They had five callers.

RUTH: Four.

HELEN: Five with you.

RUTH: I hadn't said yes.

HELEN: That's what I said.

RUTH: I had practically said yes.

HELEN: You had packed one blouse and put it on the radiator.

RUTH: To dry.

HELEN: You hadn't washed it.

RUTH: Then it was warming.

HELEN: You didn't like that Mara had started taking the Saturday calls.

RUTH: She rushed them.

HELEN: People liked her.

RUTH: People like being rushed if you smile. They think they have somewhere to be.

HELEN: You could have gone.

RUTH: I stayed with you.

HELEN: Yes.

RUTH: I gave that up.

HELEN: You hadn't told them yes.

RUTH: Neither had I told them no.

RUTH: That was not a small thing.

HELEN: I know.

RUTH: You say it as though I used you as an excuse.

HELEN: Sometimes you do.

RUTH: And you used them as an excuse.

HELEN: Who?

RUTH: All four of them.

HELEN: Don't.

RUTH: You say they left you standing alone-

HELEN: I don't say that.

RUTH: You say you were alone.

HELEN: I was.

RUTH: Because you left.

HELEN: Yes.

RUTH: They asked you to stay.

HELEN: Yes.

RUTH: All four.

HELEN: Not at once.

RUTH: You came out of eighty years with people who loved you and spoke as though someone had locked a door behind you.

HELEN: They loved me as part of something I could no longer find myself inside.

RUTH: You were the part everyone knew.

HELEN: That was the problem.

RUTH: You did the beautiful work. They did everything that let you do it.

HELEN: And when somebody praised the work, there was no sentence in which I had made anything.

RUTH: You left them.

HELEN: I left them.

RUTH: Good.

HELEN: Good?

RUTH: At last you say it without making yourself the one who was left.

HELEN: I have said it for three hundred years.

RUTH: Not here.

HELEN looks around the room.

HELEN: No.

RUTH: Here you needed me because they were gone.

HELEN: I needed you because I had gone.

A silence.

RUTH: You might have come back.

HELEN: To them?

RUTH: To yourself.

HELEN: That is what I was trying to do.

RUTH: By putting me in you.

HELEN: By asking you to stay while I found out if being alone would kill me.

RUTH: It didn't.

HELEN: You helped.

RUTH: I know.

HELEN: You still tell it as though nobody else could have.

RUTH: Mara would have rushed it.

HELEN almost laughs. RUTH does not mean it entirely as a joke. HELEN's laugh becomes real anyway, and after a moment RUTH gives in.

RUTH: She called everything too fast.

HELEN: I believe you.

RUTH: You never met her.

HELEN: I have been hearing about her for three centuries.

RUTH: Not often.

HELEN: She had red hair, then silver, then something you said was not hair. She stole your Thursday hall. She married a man with a bad knee and a woman who made jam. She died twice and neither time lasted.

RUTH: It wasn't jam.

HELEN: All right.

RUTH: It was a preserve.

HELEN: Of course.

The laughter goes. The quiet that follows is easier and therefore more dangerous.

RUTH: There was a place near Louth where they put us above the kitchen. Four beds, but there were five of us because Dennis had brought his niece. Nobody knew why. She didn't dance. She had a little dog that would only eat white food.

HELEN: I don't know this one.

RUTH: Yes, you do.

HELEN: No.

RUTH: The landlady sent up a plate of fish and the dog-

RUTH stops.

HELEN: Ate the wallpaper.

RUTH: That was a different dog.

HELEN: How many travelling dogs were there?

RUTH: More than you would think.

HELEN: What did this one do?

RUTH: I can't remember.

HELEN: You have told me every detail except the event.

RUTH: The details were the event. We were tired. The room smelled of onions. Dennis's niece cried because the dog wouldn't eat the fish. Mara did something kind, which annoyed me.

HELEN: What?

RUTH: I said I can't remember.

HELEN: All right.

RUTH: It will come back.

HELEN: You can tell me if it does.

RUTH: When?

HELEN has no useful answer. She bends, takes the bag from beneath her chair, and sets it upright by the entrance.

RUTH watches the whole journey of it.

RUTH: Is that mine?

HELEN: Kit's.

RUTH: You know what I mean.

HELEN: Yes.

RUTH: And Thursday?

HELEN: We haven't arranged Thursday.

RUTH looks at the displaced chair.

RUTH: Or the chair.

HELEN: Or the chair.

RUTH: Or how I come back.

HELEN: No.

RUTH: All right.

RUTH does not take the bag yet.

HELEN: What happened to the fish?

RUTH: I don't know.

HELEN: That is going to bother me.

RUTH: Good.

They sit with that.

7. A Visit Rehearsed Badly

HELEN: Try once.

RUTH: What?

HELEN: Meeting me.

RUTH: I'm meeting you now.

HELEN: The next time may not be like now.

RUTH: You said you weren't arranging the next time.

HELEN: I'm not. I want to know if we can do it.

RUTH: Before I go.

HELEN: Yes.

RUTH: So that if we can't, I don't?

HELEN: No.

RUTH: Then what difference does it make?

HELEN: I don't know. Please.

RUTH looks at the bag by the entrance, then at HELEN.

RUTH: All right.

HELEN does not offer her hand. She loosens the familiar square of her body. There is no harbour to share now, and no KIT to recognise the change for RUTH. HELEN remains attentive, but not in a sequence RUTH can predict.

RUTH: Have you started?

HELEN: Yes.

RUTH: You look tired.

HELEN: I am also tired.

RUTH: From the water?

HELEN: From this.

RUTH: I meant before.

HELEN: I know.

RUTH waits for the familiar correction or reassurance. It does not come.

RUTH: Sal stands too close when she explains things.

HELEN: Does she?

RUTH: You know she does.

HELEN: I know you said so.

RUTH: Same thing.

HELEN: It isn't.

RUTH: You agree when you're being you.

HELEN: I am being me.

RUTH: You know what I mean.

HELEN: Yes.

RUTH: Then don't make me say it.

HELEN considers the request without arranging her face into the answer RUTH expects.

RUTH: What are you looking at?

HELEN: You.

RUTH: No, you're not.

HELEN: Not only.

RUTH: What else?

HELEN: Both sides of the harbour. The child telling the story badly. You.

RUTH: Stop.

HELEN gathers into the familiar manner at once.

HELEN: All right.

RUTH: You were showing off.

HELEN: You asked.

RUTH: I asked what you were looking at, not for an inventory of creation.

HELEN: That wasn't one.

RUTH: You put the child in because you knew I'd remember the water.

HELEN: I put the child in because they are still telling the story.

RUTH: Were you listening?

HELEN: Yes.

RUTH: While I was talking.

HELEN: Yes.

RUTH: That is rude.

HELEN: I have spent three centuries listening only one way in this room.

RUTH: I didn't ask you to.

HELEN: You ask me to come back properly when I don't.

RUTH: And now you are angry because I can't change fast enough on the day you brought a bag.

HELEN: No. I am angry because you said stop after less than a minute and still won't tell me how you'll come back.

RUTH: I don't know how I'll come back.

HELEN: But I am meant to.

RUTH: You know this room.

HELEN: I knew where you kept the tea. I didn't know about Sal.

RUTH: Don't use my words as though you've caught me stealing.

HELEN: Then hear them before you give them to me.

RUTH turns away. Anger fixes HELEN more firmly in the familiar manner. Both notice; neither can make use of it.

RUTH: I want to know my daughter when she visits.

HELEN: I want to know my mother.

RUTH: You do.

HELEN: You are about to learn to move through bodies I have never seen with people whose number you cannot tell me.

RUTH: Nine or ten.

HELEN: Thank you.

RUTH: I am still your mother.

HELEN: And I am still your daughter.

RUTH: Then come back when I ask.

HELEN: You see?

RUTH looks towards the entrance.

RUTH: Kit does know you like that.

HELEN: Some of me.

RUTH: They like it.

HELEN: Sometimes.

RUTH: You like them there.

HELEN: I did.

RUTH: You can let them back.

HELEN: That is not the same as trusting them.

RUTH: No.

HELEN: You can visit and not know me immediately.

RUTH: That sounds like something written beside a dangerous step.

HELEN: Will you try?

RUTH: I did.

HELEN: Once, for less than a minute.

RUTH: It was a long minute.

HELEN: Will you try another time?

RUTH: I won't promise what shape I'll be in when I do.

HELEN: That wasn't the question.

RUTH: It is the answer.

KIT appears at the entrance. They do not come fully in until both women have seen them.

KIT: Can I?

HELEN: You can come into the room.

KIT enters. HELEN's distinction hurts, but it is clear.

RUTH: What did Neri say?

KIT: That I should come.

RUTH: Here?

KIT: There. When I can.

HELEN: And the others?

KIT: They started.

HELEN: Without you.

KIT: Yes.

RUTH: Did they mind?

KIT: They didn't stop. I could see enough to know they didn't stop.

HELEN: You looked?

KIT: Neri invited me. Just for that. To see they weren't waiting.

HELEN: And then?

KIT: They closed it.

RUTH: Sensible.

KIT: Yes.

KIT looks at the familiar HELEN, then deliberately does not ask for more.

HELEN: Did you tell them what you said?

KIT: I told Neri you hadn't promised and Ruth hadn't agreed.

HELEN: And the rest?

KIT: No.

A pause.

RUTH: Were they angry?

KIT: Neri was quiet.

RUTH: That isn't an answer.

KIT: It was when Neri did it.

RUTH: Ah.

KIT: They said the door would still be there.

RUTH: They sound exhausting.

KIT: You would hate them.

RUTH: I might.

KIT: They would like you.

RUTH: That's worse.

A small laugh is available. HELEN does not take it. KIT accepts that too.

KIT: Have I missed it?

HELEN: Yes.

KIT: I know. I meant this.

KIT gestures to the bag, the coat, the displaced chair.

RUTH: Nearly.

RUTH stands and puts on her coat.

One sleeve turns partly inside out. She ignores it.

8. Ruth Goes

KIT: I can take you.

RUTH: No.

KIT: I know where it is.

RUTH: So do I.

KIT: You said the numbers change.

RUTH: The house doesn't.

HELEN: You don't have to go straight there.

RUTH: Where else would I go?

HELEN: Anywhere.

RUTH: That's where Kit told me to look. There was nothing there.

KIT: I said you could look anywhere.

RUTH: Exactly.

RUTH lifts the bag. It is almost empty.

RUTH: This is very light.

HELEN: There wasn't much you wanted.

RUTH: I thought there'd be more.

HELEN: We can find more.

RUTH: No.

RUTH puts the bag down and checks her pockets. Spectacles. Nothing else.

KIT: You have your glasses.

RUTH: I know.

KIT: Sorry.

RUTH: You're both going to have to find new things to say.

HELEN nearly reaches to straighten RUTH's sleeve. She stops herself.

HELEN: When you go through, this time you're leaving here.

RUTH: Yes.

RUTH: If I call you?

HELEN: I won't hear you unless I have come to meet you.

RUTH: Or invited me to you.

HELEN: Yes.

RUTH: So this is the last time I can make you answer.

HELEN: Yes.

A pause.

HELEN: Are you sure?

RUTH: No.

HELEN: We can wait.

RUTH: For what?

HELEN: Until you are.

RUTH: You weren't sure when you left the four of them.

HELEN: I was sure I had to leave.

RUTH: That's all I'm sure of.

RUTH picks up the bag again.

HELEN: Sal may be awful.

RUTH: Sal is awful.

HELEN: The others may be worse.

RUTH: Some of them are.

HELEN: You might hate the dance.

RUTH: I might be very bad at it.

HELEN: You hate being bad at things.

RUTH: Everyone does. I simply don't pretend it builds character.

KIT: What if you like it?

RUTH looks at KIT.

RUTH: Then I'll have wasted a great deal of everyone's time.

HELEN: You won't have wasted-

RUTH: Helen.

HELEN: No.

RUTH: I don't want the proper answer.

HELEN: All right.

RUTH: I want you to be annoyed.

HELEN: I am furious.

RUTH: Good.

HELEN: You could have told me weeks ago.

RUTH: You could have asked without a bag.

HELEN: I did ask.

RUTH: You sent places.

HELEN: I found six.

RUTH: You enjoyed finding them.

HELEN: I made a table.

RUTH: I know.

HELEN: There were columns.

RUTH: I know, dear.

HELEN laughs. It catches badly, but it is a laugh.

RUTH: There you are.

HELEN: Where?

RUTH: Never mind.

RUTH turns to the entrance. The inverted sleeve catches against the bag handle.

HELEN: Wait.

RUTH stops, but does not turn.

HELEN: Your sleeve.

HELEN reaches. RUTH moves the caught arm away without meaning to. They both feel the refusal.

RUTH: Kit.

KIT comes close. They turn the sleeve back and free it from the handle. The work is intimate and ordinary. RUTH lets them finish.

KIT: There.

RUTH: Thank you.

KIT: I really can walk with you.

RUTH: You have somewhere to arrive late.

KIT: So do you.

RUTH: Mine haven't started until I get there.

KIT: The dance has.

RUTH: Not the one I call.

KIT smiles. RUTH shoulders the bag.

HELEN: Will you tell me if you remember what Mara did for the dog?

RUTH: If I remember.

HELEN: And if you want to.

RUTH: Don't spoil it.

HELEN: Sorry.

RUTH faces HELEN. Neither offers a hand.

RUTH: Put the chair wherever you like.

HELEN: I will.

RUTH: You won't.

HELEN: No.

RUTH: All right.

RUTH turns to KIT.

RUTH: Don't promise anyone for me.

KIT: No.

RUTH: That was not a request for a promise.

KIT: I know.

RUTH: There you go again.

RUTH goes through the entrance.

HELEN takes one involuntary step after her and stops.

The room does not change.

They wait long enough for HELEN to know RUTH is no longer here.

HELEN's familiar readiness does not survive the silence. With no one left to supply it for, her attention widens. KIT receives none of it.

KIT: Has she gone?

HELEN: Yes.

KIT: Can you feel where?

HELEN: No.

HELEN stands in the quiet she asked for.

9. For the Door

KIT remains near the entrance. HELEN remains one step short of it.

KIT: Are you all right?

HELEN: No.

KIT: Do you want me to go?

HELEN: I don't know.

KIT: All right.

KIT waits without filling the answer in.

HELEN: What are they doing?

KIT: Neri's house?

HELEN: Your house.

KIT: I don't know if it is yet.

HELEN: You said it began.

KIT: They began. I'm still here.

HELEN: What did you miss?

KIT: They broke the first loaf.

HELEN: You made bread?

KIT: Neri did. I was supposed to burn the crust.

HELEN: On purpose?

KIT: It smells like the place we met. Neri hates it. That was the joke.

HELEN: What did they do?

KIT: Let someone else burn it. Badly.

KIT: Then they stood together for the first time. Neri showed me after, only enough to see the place where I should have been.

HELEN: Is there still one?

KIT: They said there was.

HELEN: Do you believe them?

KIT: I believed them before. That's why I wanted you there.

HELEN: To check?

KIT: To have someone I knew while I stopped being the person they knew.

HELEN looks at KIT.

KIT: Will you come?

HELEN: I am not opening the water again.

KIT: I know.

HELEN: I may not open anything to you tonight.

KIT: I know.

HELEN: Or tomorrow.

KIT: I know.

HELEN: Stop saying you know.

KIT: All right.

A pause.

KIT: Will you come anyway?

HELEN: I don't know.

KIT: Then I'll go.

KIT does not move at once. Then they do. HELEN lets them reach the entrance.

HELEN: Kit.

KIT turns.

HELEN: I don't want to be alone in here yet.

KIT: You don't have to come in with me.

HELEN: No.

KIT: You could walk as far as the door.

HELEN: Their door?

KIT: Yes.

HELEN: And then?

KIT: Then you decide.

HELEN looks back at the room. The chair is still displaced. The mug is still on the table. The scarf and coat are gone; the flask remains.

HELEN: They have already seen you arrive.

KIT: Not like this.

HELEN: How do you want to arrive?

KIT: I don't know.

HELEN: Kit.

KIT: I thought I would be different by now.

HELEN: You are.

KIT: Not usefully.

HELEN laughs despite herself. KIT looks grateful, which almost ends it.

KIT: Could you-

They stop.

HELEN: What?

KIT: I was going to ask you to be the way you were when we came in.

HELEN: Why?

KIT: Because I know where your hand is then.

HELEN does not change.

KIT: Forget it.

HELEN: No.

KIT: You don't have to.

HELEN: I know.

HELEN remains vividly elsewhere and wholly in front of KIT.

KIT: Mum?

HELEN: Yes.

KIT steadies.

KIT: Will you walk with me?

HELEN: To the door.

KIT: To the door.

KIT holds out a hand, then begins to lower it.

HELEN chooses the familiar square of her body. She takes KIT's hand.

KIT does not pull.

HELEN leads them through the entrance.

The room remains.

No one comes back for the chair.